Orality and Bible Translation

Two Approaches to Orality and Scripture

Oral-Aural

- Focuses on orality inherent in the biblical text
- A focus on the performative nature of oral traditions
- Founded upon notion of an 'oral' Hebrew Bible
- Focus on sound and performance

Sociolinguistic

- Audience focus
- Limited literacy
- Founded in anthropology, psychiatry, linguistics and philology
- Focus on language and cognition

Vries, Laurens de. "Views of orality and the translation of the Bible." In *Orality and translation*, edited by Paul F. Bandia. London: Routledge, Taylor & Francis Group, 2017.

Orality

Can mean different things to different people.

Orality and Scripture

Perhaps there is a middle-way?

- Dynamic interface between oral and textuality
- Rejection of the Great-Divide
- Scribal culture
  - Scripture as *aide-memoire*
  - Performative Nature of Scripture
- Oral Hermeneutics
  - Embodied Cognition
  - Relational
  - Phronesis

How does this impact translation/consulting?

Cognition

- Perceiving
- Reasoning
- Learning
- Evaluating
- Remembering

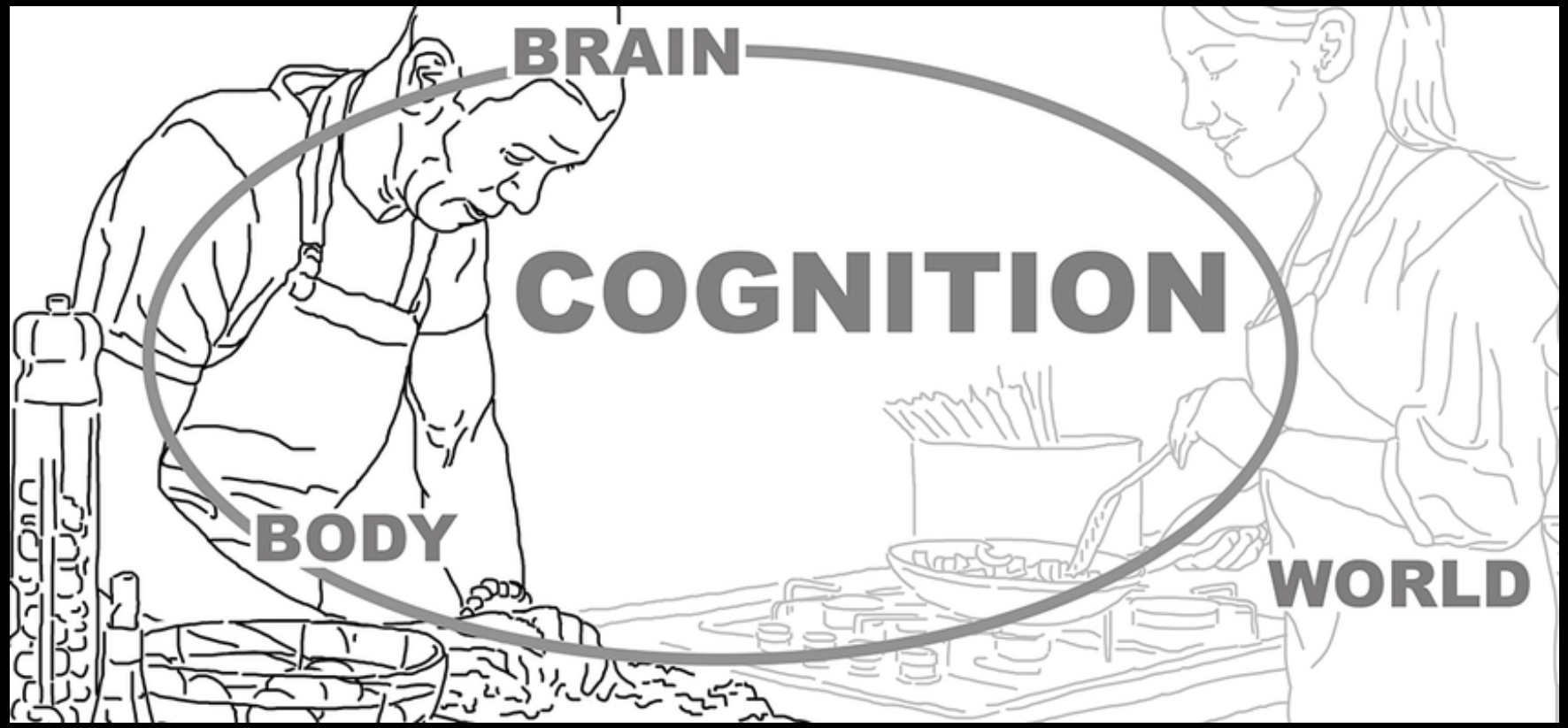
Cognition as

Computational Processing

Oral Cognition

- The world invades our neat computations
- Educational philosophy has tended to interiorize cognition
- Descartes' Cogito - "I think, therefore I am."

"Good news.
The test results show it's a metaphor."

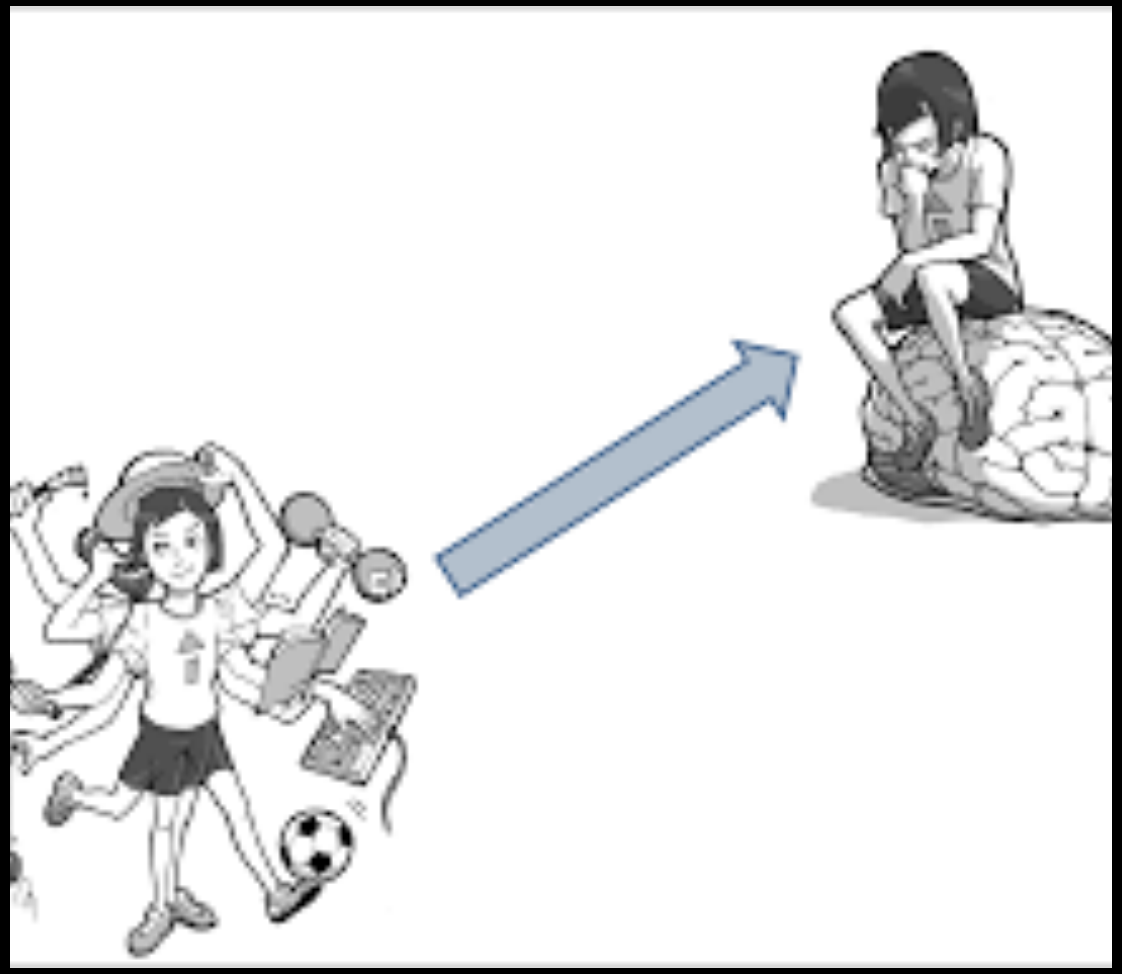


I am, therefore, I think

Embodied Cognition

- **grounded**

Relates to the physical world.



Embodied Cognition

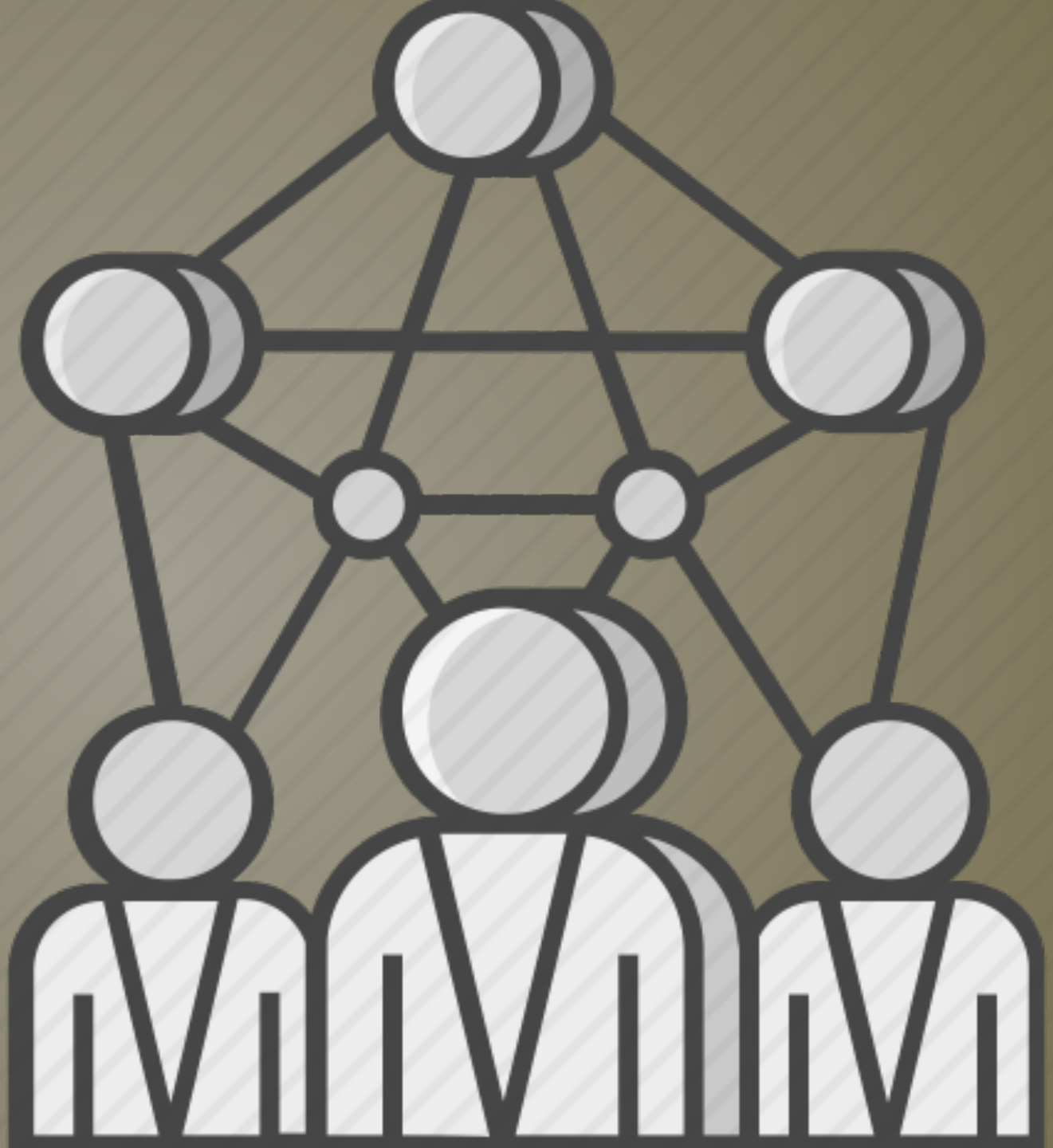
- **embodied**

Sensorimotor perception

Embodied Cognition

- **situated**

Sociocultural context



How does this impact translation/consulting?

Orality and Phronesis

Phronesis – practical wisdom

'…a state of grasping the truth, involving reason, concerned with action, about what is good or bad for a human being.'

-Aristotle

‘grasping truth’

- Oral epistemology
  - Embodied truth
  - Worldview-dependent
    - Honor-shame
    - Fear-Power

‘involving reason’

- Oral rationality
  - High context
  - narrative

‘concerned with action’

- Oral praxis
  - ‘Don’t tell me what to think, tell me what I should do’
  - From knowledge to wisdom

‘about what is good or bad for a human being’

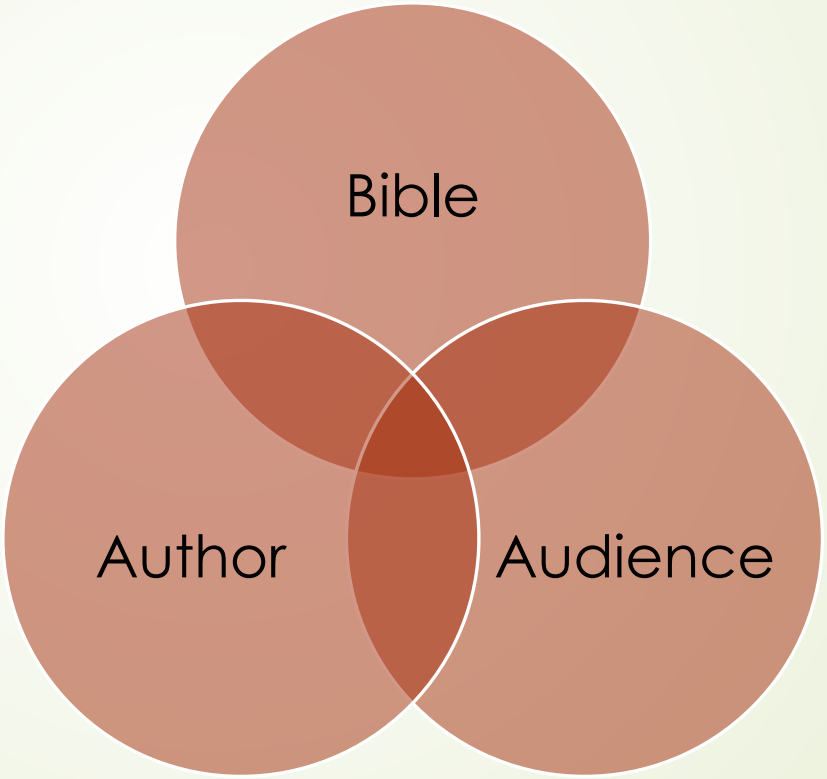
- Oral ethics
  - Focus on community and relationships
  - Proverbs, songs, parables

How does this impact translation/consulting?

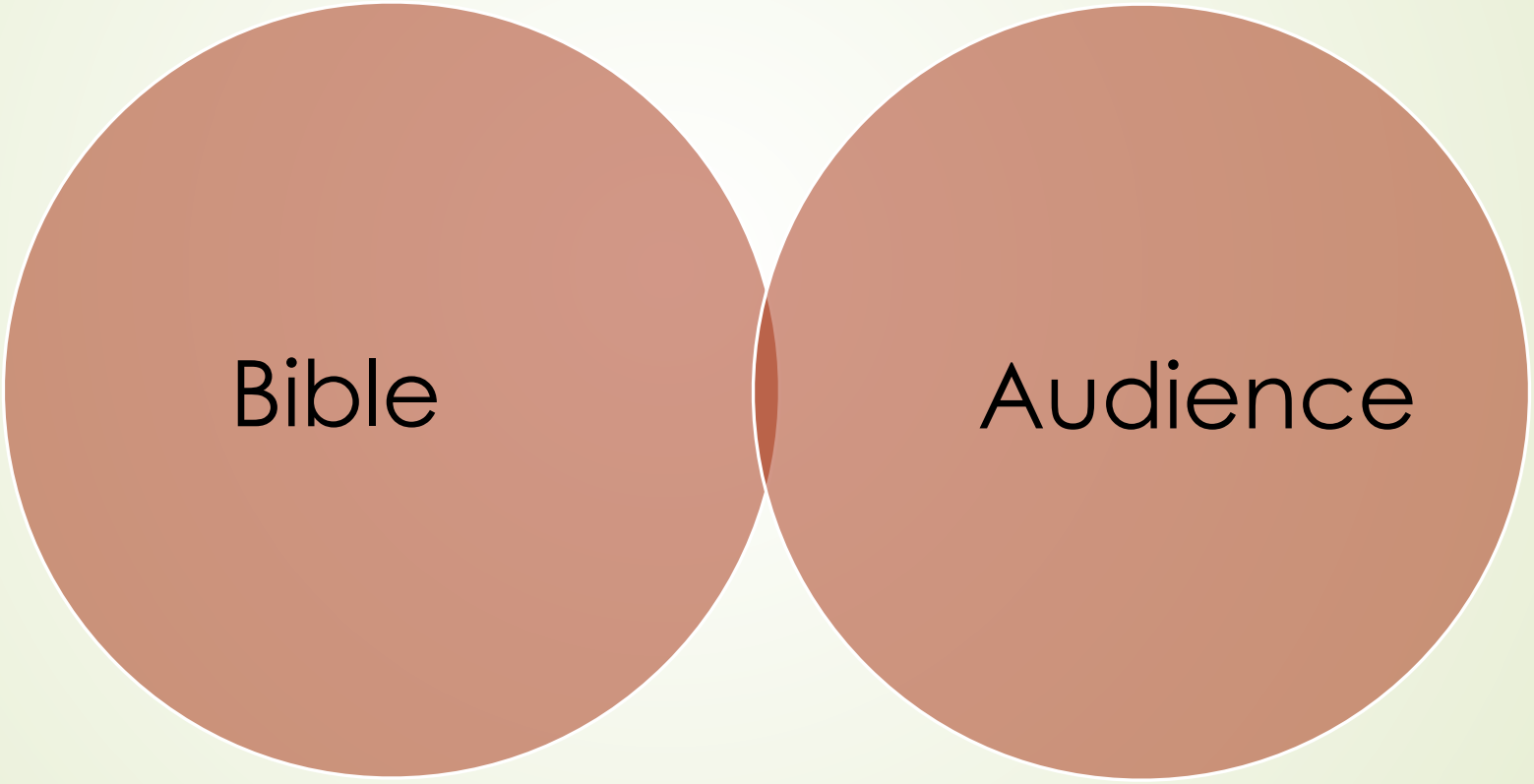
Oral Synthesis

Kelber, Werner H. *The Oral and the Written Gospel: The Hermeneutics of Speaking and Writing in the Synoptic Tradition, Mark, Paul, and Q*. Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1983.

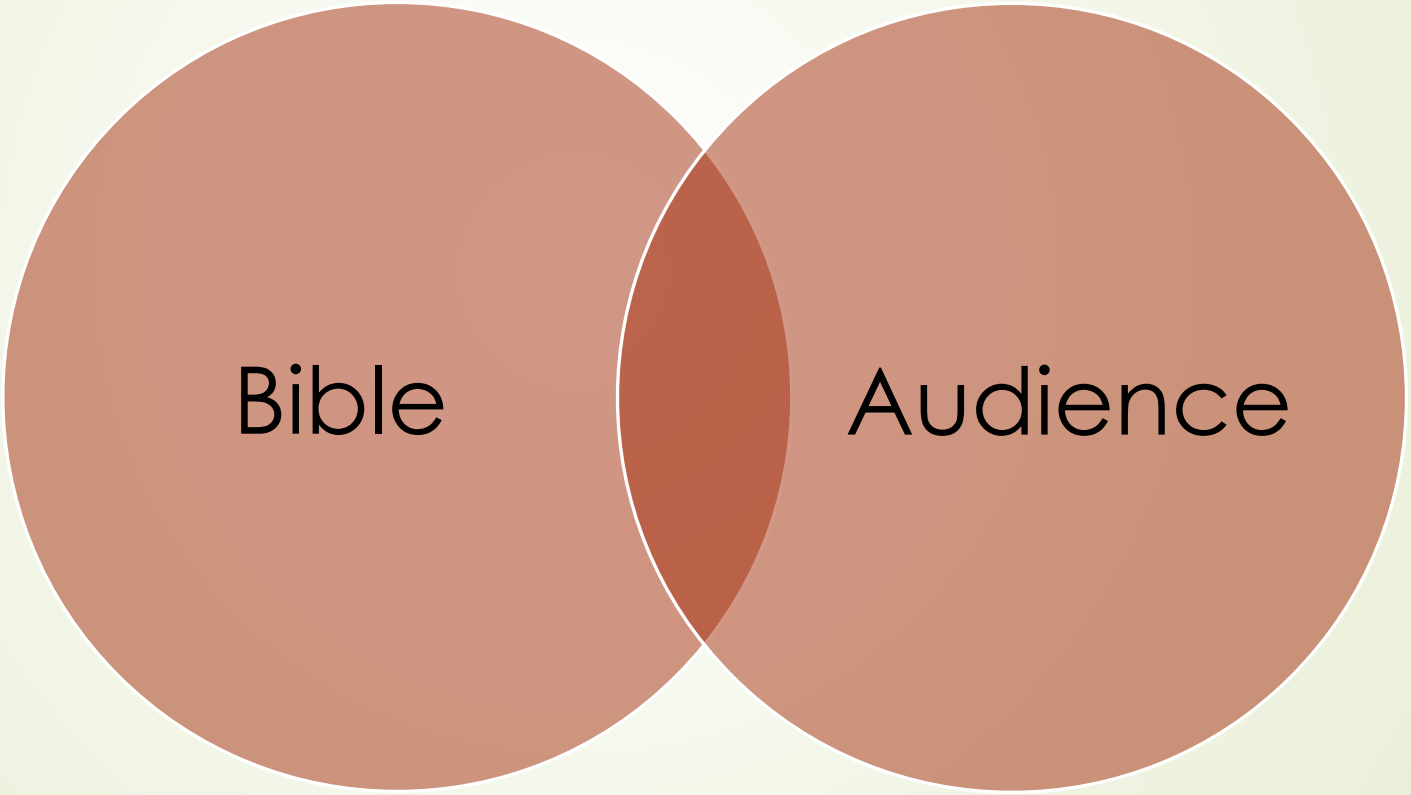
Fusion of Three Horizons

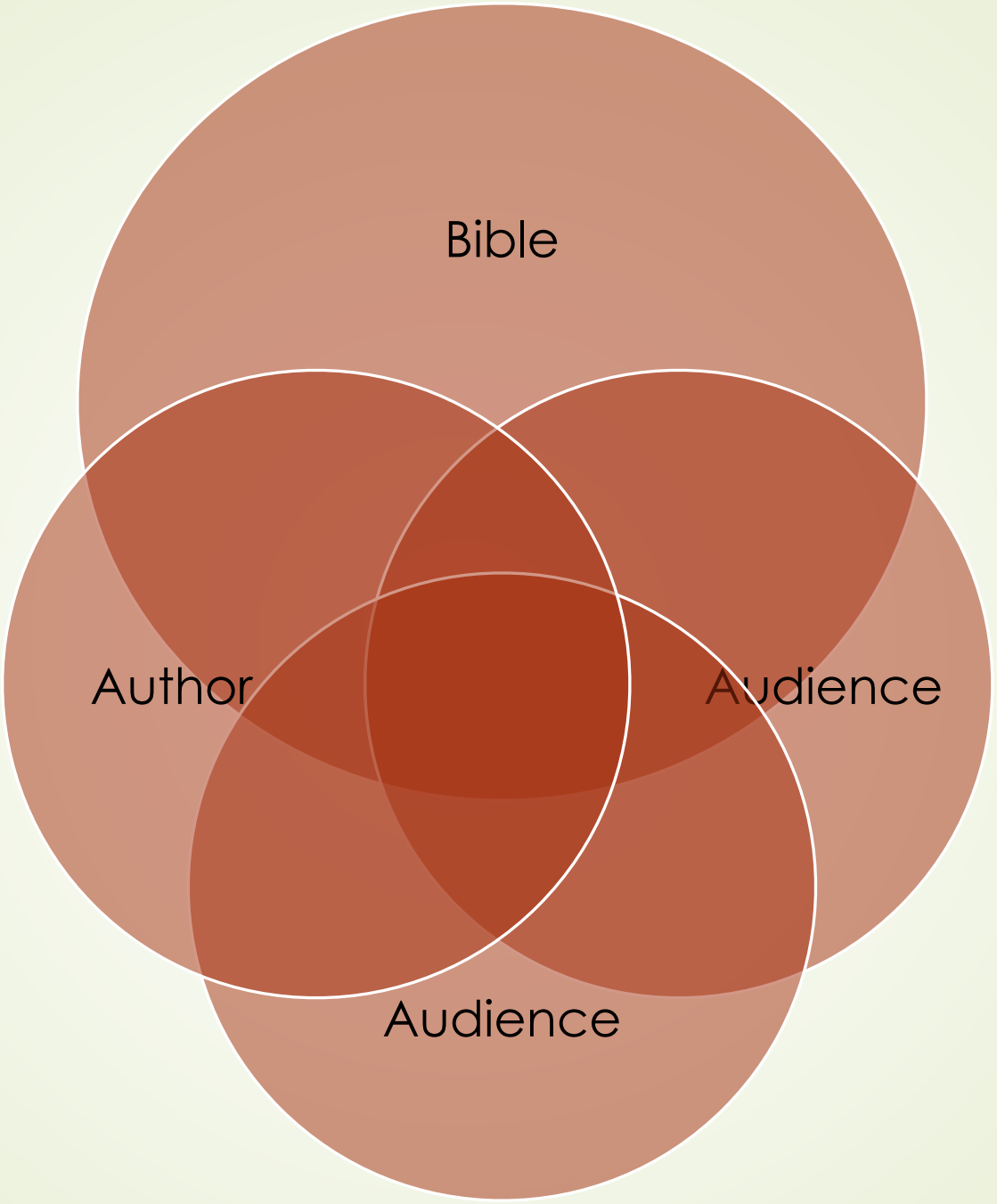


Reading = Absent Author in an Oral World



Hearing = greater access, but still an absent Author in an Oral World




Bible
Author
Audience
Audience

How does this impact translation/consulting?

Further reading

- Botha, Pieter J. J. *Orality and Literacy in Early Christianity*. Vol. 5. Eugene, Oregon: Cascade Books, 2012.
- Carr, David McLain. *Writing on the Tablet of the Heart: Origins of Scripture and Literature*. Oxford; New York: Oxford University Press, 2005.
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- Steffen, Tom, and William Bjoraker. *RETURN OF ORAL HERMENEUTICS*. [S.l.]: WIPF & STOCK PUB, 2020.
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- Wendland, Ernst R. *Orality and the Scriptures: Composition, Translation, and Transmission*. Publications in Translation and Textlinguistics 6. Dallas, Texas: SIL International, 2013.